

SESSION ZERO: FOUNDATIONS

The Qilvayas Symphony

A table-setting primer for the Dungeon Master — 4 to 6 players, characters starting at 3rd level

PURPOSE OF THIS SESSION

Session Zero is played out of character. Its job is to produce five things before dice ever hit the table: a party with all three academy houses represented, a shared history that explains why these specific people trust each other, an admission story for each character that hands the DM a personal thread to pull later, a named mercenary company the players are invested in founding, and a common understanding of tone. Everything below serves one of those five outputs.

The party begins as final-year students at the Imperial Academy of the Lupine Throne, already a cohesive unit, currently away from the capital completing their final field exercise. Session Zero establishes how they became that unit; Session One opens with the exercise already underway.

CHARACTER CREATION RULES

- **Level:** 3rd. This puts subclasses online for every class and lets the party absorb the Session One climax without a tuned kid-gloves encounter.
- **Ability Scores:** 27-point buy or standard array (15, 14, 13, 12, 10, 8), DM's preference. Avoid rolled stats for this campaign — the political and social pillars punish a party with a dump-stat face.
- **Hit Points:** Maximum at 1st level, average (rounded up) at 2nd and 3rd.
- **Races and Sources:** DM's discretion. Note that Drow carry imperial resonance in this setting — the Emperor himself is Drow — so a Drow PC is a statement, not just a stat line. Worth a conversation if anyone picks one.
- **Equipment:** Standard class and background starting equipment, plus the Academy Field Kit: an academy uniform and house insignia, a student signet (functions as identification in imperial-loyal territory), a writing kit, and a 25 gp field stipend remaining from the exercise advance.
- **Advancement:** Milestone leveling recommended. Suggested pace: 4th level after the meeting with the Seeress concludes (early Session Three); 5th at the close of the Proving (end of Session Four); 6th at the Second Seal (end of Session Six); 7th in the Witness Hall (end of Session Seven); 8th when the Vigil is kept (end of Session Eight). XP totals are listed in the session documents for tables that prefer XP.

HOUSE SELECTION AND PARTY BALANCE

Each character selects a primary house per the class placement guide in the campaign sourcebook (summarized

below). Left entirely alone, most parties skew heavily toward House of the Craft, because it is deliberately the catch-all for casters and specialists. That skew will make Session One harder than it needs to be. Before backgrounds get locked, ask the table directly: who wants to be the one who fights, who wants to be the one who talks, who wants to be the one who notices things. Aim for at least one Sword-primary and one Seal-primary (or Seal-flavored) character in any group of four or more.

House of the Sword: Barbarian, Fighter, Monk. Paladins whose concept is a warrior shaped by faith.

House of the Seal: Paladins who see themselves as religious champions first; Clerics with a doctrinal or pastoral focus.

House of the Craft: Artificer, Bard, Cleric, Druid, Ranger, Rogue, Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard.

Every character should also name one cross-training discipline from a house other than their primary — a single sentence is enough ("took two years of siege engineering," "studied contract law," "trained with the legion quartermasters"). This costs nothing mechanically. It exists so the DM can hand out moments of expertise later, and because cross-training is the academy's entire institutional philosophy.

ADMISSION STORIES

The capital academy admits through a lottery that is less fair than it appears. Each player chooses (or rolls d6) an admission story. Each one hands the DM a thread: a family, a patron, a debt, a home region, a resentment. Record these — they are the cheapest personal hooks the campaign will ever get. Anchor each story to a real place: the sourcebook's Atlas of the Fractured Empire names the regions (the loyalist Ostmark and Suthmark, the warlord Brekelands, the merchant delta of Velmareth, the See of Orlath, and the rest), and an admission story tied to a named territory becomes a plot hook the moment that territory enters play. One flag: a Drow character is now an even larger statement than before — the Drow are the Founder's Blood, the dynasty's own nearly-vanished people, and a Drow stranger will be read as dynastic kin, claimant, or something without a name (see the sourcebook, Peoples of the Empire, before allowing one). A character from Tarnovar is a statement of similar order, and worth a private conversation — the DM should read the Atlas entry's DM-only note before allowing it, and no Tarnovari character should begin play knowing anything their culture itself does not know.

1. **Lottery Winner:** A genuine winner. Talented, probably common-born, owes nobody anything — and is quietly resented by classmates who know how rare that is. Thread: the home community that celebrated them, and what it expects back.

2. **The Donation:** A wealthy family made a generous gift to the academy, and admission followed. The character knows it. Thread: the family's expectations, and whether the character intends to meet them.
3. **The Hostage:** A son or daughter of a border lord or ambitious noble, kept close to the capital to ensure a parent's good behavior. In law this is hostage-diplomacy, a formal category and emphatically not bondage: the character retains full legal personhood and is owed treatment as an honored, if constrained, guest (see the sourcebook, Law, Oath, and Bound Labor). Whether their actual experience has matched that standard is the character's to decide. Thread: the parent's politics, and what happens back home if relations with the throne sour.
4. **The Protégé:** A regional lord or power spotted talent and sponsored it, expecting a return on the investment. Thread: the patron, and the first favor they will eventually call in.
5. **The True Believer:** Sought admission out of genuine conviction — in the empire, the Lupine Matron, or the Emperor's restoration. Thread: what happens to faith when the institution disappoints it.
6. **The Quiet Irregularity:** The paperwork says lottery. It wasn't — a forged record, a bribed clerk, a swapped name. The character may not even know who arranged it, or why. Thread: whoever did it, and what they wanted. (**DM note:** this one is a gift — it can be wired into any faction later.)

FORGING THE PARTY

The academy houses students in mixed residential halls by year and cohort, so the party plausibly shared a dormitory for four years. Do not just assert the bond — co-author it. Put these questions to the table and let players answer in any order, building on each other:

- What incident in your first or second year turned you from hallmates into allies? (A hazing gone wrong, an unfair accusation one of you took the blame for, a house competition you conspired to win.)
- Which earlier field exercise did you survive together, and what went wrong on it? (This is the party's shared war story. It should have gone badly enough to matter.)
- Each player, name one thing you trust absolutely about the character to your left, and one habit of theirs that drives you mad.
- Who first said, out loud, "we should do this for ourselves after graduation" — and who took the most convincing?

THE COMPANY

Have the players name their future mercenary company during Session Zero, before the campaign begins. This is deliberate. The company is the party's shared dream — the plan the vision is about to interrupt — and it lands much harder if it is their invention rather than a line of backstory. Let them argue about the name. Let them design a charter, a motto, a rule ("we never work for slavers," "equal shares, always"). Every rule they write is a promise — and in this campaign, promises are load-bearing. Write them all down.

RUNNING SESSION ZERO: A TWO-HOUR PLAN

Session Zero is the only session in this campaign with no pacing budget, which is a gap, because it is the session most likely to sprawl. Two hours, six blocks. Everything below is in service of the five outputs named at the top.

Block	Minutes	What Happens
The pitch	15	The DM describes the setting in five sentences and the tone in three. Do not read the sourcebook aloud. Say: a fading empire, a young emperor trying to fix it, a school that trains its administrators, and a shared dream of the capital burning. Then stop talking.
Tone and lines	20	The safety and tone conversation below. Do this before anybody has a character they are attached to.
Houses and roles	20	Class, house, and the who-fights-who-talks-who-notices conversation. Aim for one Sword-primary and one Seal-flavored character in any group of four or more.
Admission stories	25	Roll or choose, and go round the table so each player hears the others'. This is the block most likely to run long and it is the block most worth letting run.
Forging the party	30	The four co-authoring questions. Answered aloud, in any order, building on each other.
The Company	10	Name it, describe the sign, and write it down where everyone can see it.

The DM has one more thing to open tonight, and it is not a player-facing document: the standing sheet. Twelve factions, one number each from zero to five, all of them at zero this evening, moved once at the end of every session (see the sourcebook, Standing: What the Empire Remembers). Every session module closes with a note on what moved and why, and the whole system is a page of arithmetic that turns the campaign's politics from a thing the DM remembers into a thing the DM can read. Open it beside the Branch Ledger before Session One and fill in both at the same time, or neither will get filled in at all. One warning, kept from the players for as long as possible: the Office of Omens is the score they should want low, and its number will go up whether they earn it or not.

TONE, LINES, AND THE CONVERSATION BEFORE THE CAMPAIGN

This campaign includes an empire that keeps people in bound labor, a church that conducts trials for lycanthropy, a massacre of worshippers at a festival, a district burned to end a rebellion, and a village where servant girls do not come home. All of it is written to be taken seriously rather than used for shock, and none of it works if somebody at the table is enduring it politely.

What to say. Name the heavy material out loud, before characters exist. The list above takes ninety seconds to read and it is the whole of the obligation. Then ask two questions and take the answers without discussion: is there anything here you would rather this campaign did not go near, and is there anything here you actively want it to. One further check belongs in the same breath and is easy to forget, because it is about the shape of the campaign rather than its content: this campaign poses questions with no clean answer, and whether the empire should be restored at all is genuinely contestable rather than rhetorical. A table that wants a clear villain will be unhappy for eight sessions and it is far kinder to find that out now.

The second question matters as much as the first. A player who says I want the bound-labor material to be real is telling the DM where to aim, and the campaign is far better for knowing. The Bound-Freed background in the Player's Companion exists because somebody will want it.

How to stop something mid-session. Agree one word, out loud, that any player including the DM can say to move the camera. It needs no explanation at the time and no discussion afterward unless the person wants one. Agree it now, in Session Zero, so that using it later is a procedure rather than an interruption.

What this campaign will not do. State it plainly so nobody has to wonder: sexual violence is not depicted, described, or implied on screen anywhere in this corpus, and the Greywell material is written specifically to be horror about disappearance and complicity rather than about what happens to the girls. Harm to children happens off screen and is referred to rather than shown. If the table wants either line drawn differently, that is the table's to decide, and Session Zero is when.

WHAT THE PLAYERS SHOULD KNOW, AND WHAT THEY SHOULD NOT

Hand out the Player Guide and the Player's Companion before or at Session Zero. Both are written to be read by players and neither contains a spoiler. Everything a character would plausibly have learned in eighteen years of imperial life is in them.

Safe to know. The empire's history and its fracture. The Matron, the Aspects, the saints, the Vigil. The Atlas and the powers who hold each region. The calendar, the money, the titles, and how to address a Prelate without embarrassing yourself. The Academy, its houses, its field exercises, and its commencement.

Not to know, and worth guarding. The content of the Founding Myth beyond its official version. The binding site and what is under the Old Forum. That Tarnovar descends from Threnvos's people. The Proving at all — the word, the rumor, and the fact. Sessions Three and Four work only if nobody at the table has any reason to suspect the Academy stages anything, ever, and neither player book mentions it. Anything about the shadow's mechanism — the campaign works because the players discover that broken oaths feed something, and a player who is told it in Session Zero has been robbed of the best thing this campaign does. And if a player builds a paladin or a cleric, resist the urge to foreshadow early. Their moment comes in the dark under the Old Forum, seven sessions out, and it will be worth the wait.

DM Only: the single most common way this campaign gets spoiled is a DM who is proud of the mechanism and cannot resist signposting it. Do not. Seed it constantly, confirm it never, and let the first player who says it out loud at the table have that moment entirely to themselves.

TWELVE COMPANY NAMES, IF THE TABLE STALLS

The Company block asks the players to name themselves and it is the one part of Session Zero that reliably deadlocks. Offer these only after ten minutes of genuine deadlock, and offer them as bad examples — a table will name itself instantly out of spite, which is the intended effect.

d12	Name	d12	Name
1	The Lector's Seal	7	The Eleventh Cohort
2	The Patched Standard	8	Ondrei's Correspondents
3	The Cold Door Company	9	The Unlicensed
4	Three Houses	10	The Quiet Irregularity
5	The Redwatch Concern	11	Kin of Great Timberwolf
6	The Fourth Book	12	The Lamp Left Burning

A note on the sign. Whatever the company calls itself, decide what its sign looks like, because it will be painted on a door, stamped in wax, and eventually recognized across a street by somebody who wishes them harm. A company with a sign is a company the world can react to.

THE FIRST FIVE MINUTES OF SESSION ONE

End Session Zero by describing where Session One opens, so nobody arrives cold: the party is four days east of the capital, on a field exercise that has three days left to run, in a

market town called Dravenna, and a magistrate is about to ask them for a favor he has no authority to ask. Nothing has gone wrong yet. That is the last time that sentence will be true.

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"We are the Kin of Great Timberwolf"